

DEEP
KALRA

39, ONLINE ENTREPRENEUR
FOUNDER AND CEO, MAKEMYTRIP.COM
INITIAL INVESTMENT IN 2000 Rs 9 crore
TURNOVER IN 2008 Rs 900 crore



VIKRAM SHARMA

**success
MANTRA**

Hire people better
than yourself and
empower them

**role
MODEL**

His father. He was
the one who taught
him his work ethic.

**guiding
LIGHT**

Sanjeev Bikhchandani of
Naukri.com, who gives
him professional advice

TICKETS TO RIDE

As founder and chief executive of Makemytrip.com (MMT), an online travel portal for 20 lakh people every month, Deep Kalra should be worried about how the worsening economy will hurt his revenues. But he isn't. For the 39-year-old Kalra, it's a sense of déjà vu. In 2001, just a year after he started the company, he was hit by a triple whammy—the Venture Capitalist pulled out thanks to the dotcom bubble going bust they never got the second round of funding (Rs 4.5 crore) promised to them, even as 9/11 happened followed by the December 13 attack on Parliament. To round it off, there was SARS. Eight years later, he is something of a “slow-down veteran”. “I think I'm much more mature to handle this,” he grins. Even as travel agencies are hit by slowing corporate and personal travel, MMT has seen its revenues go up, thanks to people going online in a bid to

economise. The company reported sales of Rs 900 crore in the current year (with a commission of Rs 75 crore) and is forecasting 100 per cent growth in the coming year.

Online travel is now a Rs 9,000-crore business in India, and Kalra, with a 50 per cent market share is the undisputed leader. Makemytrip.com was started to provide travel solutions for those travelling to and out of India. The company was started to provide solutions for Indians travelling in and out of the country. However, since the market for online transactions hadn't quite picked up, MMT focussed on the NRI market. “In hindsight”, says the IIM-A graduate, “it was a smart move as nearly everyone who focused on only the Indian market packed up.”

Kalra has faced his share of entrepreneurial angst in his early days. “We were very close to shutting shop,” he says, talking